

Environmental politics and institutions – Course report 2024

15 Higher education credits

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Course content summary

In terms of organization, the course consists of lectures, seminars, individual tutorials, and written assignments. All seminars are mandatory. Like previous years, the course “Environmental politics and institutions” (EPI) consists of several themes. All the themes consist of a lecture and a seminar, with a written seminar assignment hand-in. In the final part, the students write a final course paper, with supervision from course teachers. The papers are to be presented at the final seminar, which is the concluding course activity.

The lectures on the theme on 1) the genesis of environmental problems and 2) the history of environmental politics are offered via recorded lectures, made available to the students via Canvas. This change was made to avoid overlap with the new course ”Environmental Problems within Social Science: From Tragedy of the Commons to Planetary Boundaries” (SK2223), which many students take prior to the EPI course.

Students in number and grades

The number of registered students was 27. 11 students acquired the grade pass (G) and 8 pass with distinction (VG). 8 students did not finish the course. The ratio between pass and pass with distinction differ from the previous years. The share who received pass with distinction was 30 percent 2022 and 2021 and about 20 percent in 2023. In 2024, the share with VG was about 40 percent. This is likely an effect of that as many as 8 students did not finish the course.

Course evaluation

Assessment of the course

Students' course evaluations consisted of an anonymous digital course evaluation, which followed the final seminar. In total, 16 students completed the course evaluation, corresponding to about 59% of the students enrolled in the course. With an average reversed score of 3.6, the students were moderately positive about the 2024 spring term version of the course. The overall assessment remains higher in comparison with 2023, but lower as compared to 2022 and 2021.

The score for the lectures and the seminars was 3.9 and 4.2. The score for the lectures is slightly(barely) higher than 2023, but lower as compared to 2022 and 20021. The score for the seminar is substantially higher compared to 2023. The average scores for the teachers (4.2) and the literature (3.9) is also higher compared to the years before.

Table 1. Overall assessment of the course and the course content

	Mean score 2024 (n)	Mean score 2023 (n)	Mean score 2022 (n)	Mean score 2021 (n)
Overall, how would you assess the course?	3.6 (16)	3.1 (14)	4.3 (11)	4.2 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	3.9 (16)	3.8 (14)	4.5 (11)	4.2 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the literature?	3.9 (16)	3.5 (14)	4.2 (11)	4.7 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	4.2 (16)	3.2 (14)	4.5 (11)	3.6 (9)
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	4.2 (16)	3.8 (14)	4.7 (11)	4.3 (9)

Comment: Respondents were asked to respond on a scale from 5 to 1. 5= Very good, 4= rather good, 3= Neither good nor bad, 2= rather bad and 1= very bad.

When it comes to examinations, the average score for the course theme assignment and the course paper tutorials was 3.3 and 3.9, which is higher than the previous year. The score for the course paper was 3.7, which can be compared to 3.3 in the 2023 edition of the course. The score for the assessment of the organization was 3.8, which is much higher than in 2023.

Themes raised in the written comments from students:

More lectures

Some students raised the point that they wanted more lectures

Individual tutorial sessions

In full-text answers, a couple of students suggest that, instead of group tutorials, individual ones could have benefits.

More extensive feedback

Students highlighted in the evaluation that they would prefer more input on how to improve in their writing.

Better teacher coordination between supervisor and examiner

This theme suggested that some students felt that the examiner was not always on board with choices suggested by the supervisor.

Suggested changes for the next round of the course

We will start the course by introducing more clearly our idea behind the chosen structure and the benefit of focusing on the students' written output, rather than a high number of lectures. This motivation will hopefully give a better expectation of the course among the group.

Theme paper assignments seem to be the topic that received the lowest overall score from those giving feedback (3.3 on the scale from 1-5). We are thinking of slightly reduce the number of readings for the themes 1-4. This would enable a more careful reading. This will also be coupled with an emphasis on how to read academic texts with discussion about specific tips and tricks. We deem that the stated hours on the course (roughly 60 % state that they spend 31-40 hours a week and only some 13% spend more time than this) indicates that we have set the bar on the right level. However, we could probably help the students in reading more efficiently, if that is a cause of stress.

We will ensure that all teachers align on the matter of giving feedback to all students' content and writing style in assignments 1-4.